Graphic Design

# Getting your foot in the door

Summary Notes

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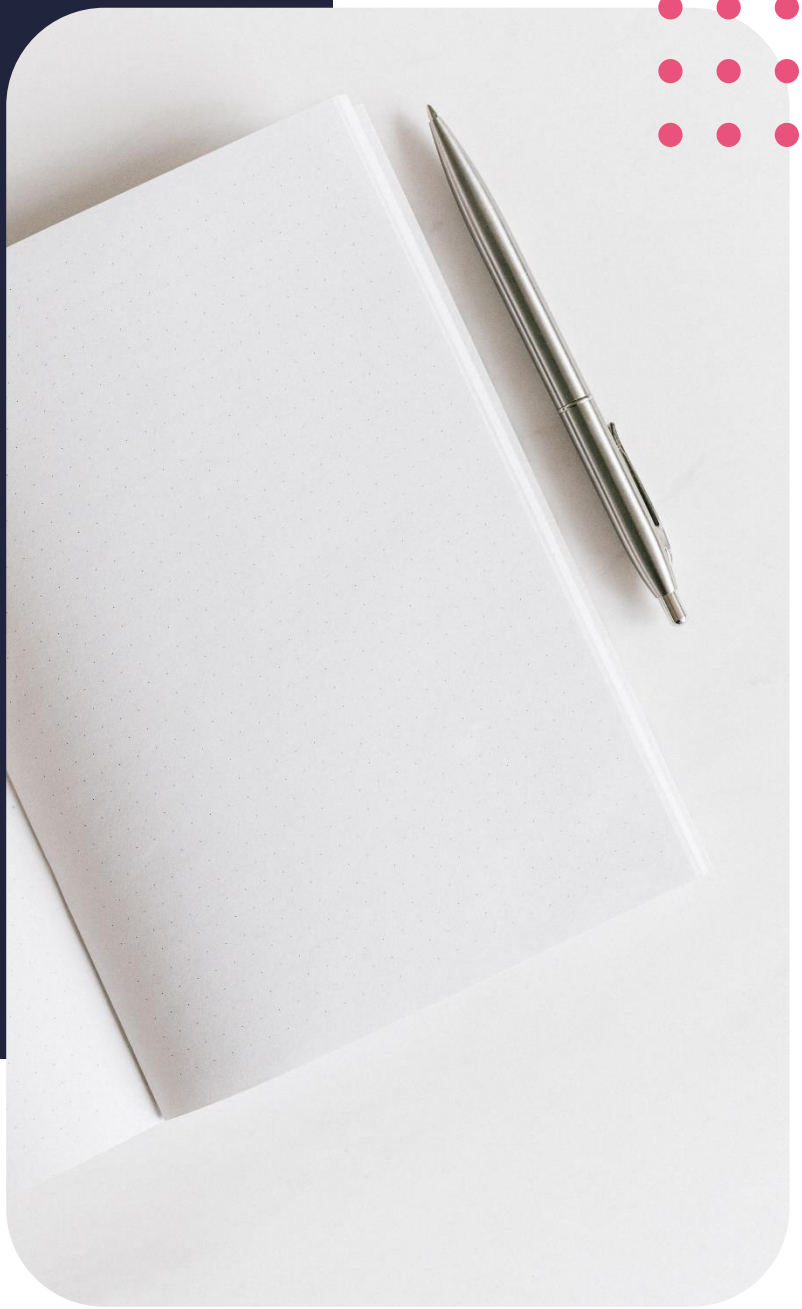

## Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Determine your personality type
- Understand interview questions and how to answer them
- Create a professional social media account
- Make use of freelance platforms

Practical lesson outcome:

Create your own freelance account on any of the platforms you were introduced to today. From a practical point, create your very first pixel art avatar.

# Introduction

We will investigate some useful features to get your foot in the door. One aspect to consider is to determine and know your personality type, your strengths and weaknesses as well as how you work with other individuals within the workplace. On top of this, having a social media account for your business or even for self-promotion is key to strut your stuff.

We will also show you some useful online communities where you can have the option to serve clients throughout the world. But what if you would like to work for a company or if you have a potential client that would like to see what you have to offer first before making a decision? Interviews are nerve-wracking whether you believe in preparing for them or not.

I will leave you with some great questions that are almost always asked during interviews, and also how to prepare and answer them if you ever need to go for an interview.

This lesson will focus on some valuable business aspects to consider when you are in the process of establishing yourself as a graphic designer. The aspects you will learn today will help a great deal for when you are starting as a freelancer or simply want to up your game as a graphic designer.

TV host Oprah Winfrey believed that when you undervalue what you do, the world will undervalue who you are. The whole process of becoming successful is about believing in yourself and working hard to achieve your goals.

Continuing what you've learnt, we will take it one step further and investigate how you can understand your strengths and weaknesses, especially in the workplace by determining your personality type.

How do you prepare for an interview, especially if you are a graphic designer? I would like to share with you some questions that you can prepare with and also how to answer them.

Having a social media presence is imperative for any type of career but since you are a graphic designer, you have the skill to make your posts look pretty amazing, so, use it to your advantage.

I will share with you some great websites that will assist you, especially on a freelance basis to find and serve clients all over the world.

# Determine your personality type

Determining your personality type is more than simply asking your friends or family to share with you their opinions. There are tests you can do to identify your strengths and weaknesses. And no, I am not referring to the Facebook game determining the type of bread your personality is but rather more professional tests.

## Myers-Briggs personality test

One such test that you can access for free is called the Myers-Briggs personality indicator. You can access it from www.16personalities.com. The Myers-Briggs test provides a valuable understanding of how you can make adjustments concerning circumstances.

## Functioning attributes

There are eight functioning attributes that determine your personality type and these can be categorised as follows:

Introversion – These are the type of people who prefer working alone or in smaller groups.

Extroversion – These individuals tend to get their energy from social occasions and like the company of others

Intuition - These personalities tend to see the bigger picture and love to find creative solutions.

Sensing – This personality type focuses on the facts and details. They have a strong common sense and focus on finding practical solutions.

Feeling personalities, these individuals are quite sensitive and determine how others would be affected by their actions. Thus they look at their feelings to aid them in handling situations.

Thinkers on the other hand take logical decisions based on facts, fairness and consistency. They like to weigh out the pros and cons before making decisions.

Lastly, our perceivers are spontaneous in that they keep their options open. They are quite flexible when it comes to making plans.

Judgers are those that stick to the rules and come prepared making sure to adhere to the schedule and plan.

Looking at these attributes, remember that you will have traits of both in each spectrum. Nobody is solely an introvert and even the most extreme introverts sometimes bloom in social situations, thus view these attributes with an open mind.

## Personality types

When we combine these attributes, we get the 16 different types of personalities that I want to briefly introduce to you.

These personality types can be summarised as follows:

1. INFP The Healer. These individuals are poetic, selfless and kind. They are imaginative idealists, guided by their core values and beliefs.
2. INTJ, The Mastermind. Masterminds are imaginative and strategic planners. They are analytical problem-solvers, eager to improve systems and processes with their innovative ideas.
3. INFJ The Counsellor. These personalities tend to be quiet and mystical optimists. They are creative nurturers with a strong sense of personal integrity and a drive to help others realise their potential.

4. INTP The Architect. These types have a great love for problem-solving, are philosophical innovators, fascinated by logical analysis, systems, and design.
5. ENFP The Champions are enthusiastic, creative and optimistic. They are people-centred creators with a focus on possibilities and have a contagious enthusiasm for new ideas, people and activities.
6. ENTJ The Commanders. These individuals are normally strategic leaders, with logical thinking. They are independent and outgoing with a motivation to organise change. They are quick to see inefficiency and conceptualise new solutions and enjoy developing long-range plans to accomplish their vision.
7. ENTP The Visionary are inspired innovators, motivated to find new solutions to intellectually challenging problems.
8. ENFJ The Teacher is an idealist organiser, driven to implement their vision of what is best for humanity.
9. ISFJ The Protector is normally a warm and considerate individual. They are industrious caretakers, loyal to traditions and organisations.
10. ISFP The Composer is a gentle and sensitive soul with flexible and realistic goals. They live in the present moment and enjoy their surroundings with cheerful, low-key enthusiasm.
11. ISTJ The Inspector is the type of personality who takes up responsibility. ISTJs are analytical, systematic and hardworking, driven to create order within systems.
12. ISTP The Craftsperson are observant artisans with an understanding of mechanics and an interest in troubleshooting. They enjoy adventure and are logical, action-orientated and spontaneous.
13. ESFJ The Providers are conscientious helpers, sensitive to the needs of others and energetically dedicated to their responsibilities. These individuals and friendly and outgoing.
14. ESFP The Performers are vivacious entertainers who charm and engage those around them. They have a playful nature and are normally enthusiastic with a strong common sense.
15. ESTJ The Supervisors are hardworking traditionalists, eager to take charge in organising projects and people. They are extremely efficient and dependable.
16. ESTP The Dynamos are energetic thrill-seekers who are at their best when putting out fires, whether literal or metaphorical. They have pragmatic problem-solving skills and are naturally curious and versatile.

## Working with different personalities

When working in an office or team setup, conflict and disagreement are inevitable. People in the office are bound to have different opinions. It is necessary to understand how to work with different personality types and also what type of person you are. This assists in giving insight as to how to handle certain situations. In this part of the lesson, we will focus on ways you can effectively deal with these issues.

Some of the key aspects to keep a cool head, especially in a working environment include:

**1. Don't take things personally.** You and your co-workers are most likely to have personality clashes. These issues can make day-to-day tasks a negative and tedious practice. It may even affect those around you. Remember, negative comments may not necessarily be directed at you, so don't take it personally. Consider creating a positive atmosphere than being the gossipmonger of the office. I normally like to joke and say that: if you don't know who the odd-ball in the office is, chances are it is you. By all means, be an odd-ball but don't add a negative connotation to this title.

**2. It's okay to disagree.** Sometimes opinions my vary. Opinions will vary due to different personalities, so see it as an opportunity to learn from each other and grow as a team.

**3. Learn to handle egos.** Some people will come into an office with a big ego. Often when there is more than one big ego, this may cause conflict in the workplace. This is usually a problem that can be spoken about and resolved. You can avoid egos by not taking things seriously and making light of any situation. Stay focused, and keep a positive mindset. Your positivity might rub off on the big egos.

# Interview questions and how to answer them

Interviews are usually a process that causes much anxiety. Whether you are applying for a contract or full-time position, the most important thing is preparation and confidence. I would like to introduce you to some insightful interview questions and also how to answer them. Your studies will not prepare you much for interviews, but you can at least understand the process of preparing for these situations.

The following frequently asked questions and tips for answering these type of questions will assist you in being prepared for your next interview.

1. **Tell me about yourself.** Don't consider this as a senseless question thinking that the employer just doesn't know what to ask you. Unstructured questions like these are a great way to test your ability and skill, also whether you can think on your feet.
   How to respond: Prepare in advance. You can almost be certain that your potential employer will ask this question Use the job description as a guide to answering this question Be succinct, honest and engaging

2. **Why do you want to work for this company?** Interviewers are interested to know why you applied for this specific role as they are looking for someone who has the same vision as the company you're applying for. What's the use if you don't have the same vision?
   How to respond: Provide an answer that will put the potential employer first Be honest and speak from your heart

3. **What gets you motivated?** This question asked aids to inspect your self-awareness and that your motivational sources are in line with the role you are applying for.
   How to respond: Be very specific when you answer this question, make sure you have real-life examples ready to go, try to tie your answers back to the role you are applying for.

4. **What are your strengths?** The interviewer is trying to gauge your technical and soft skillsets, however, they are looking to see if you are still humble about your strengths. This is also to determine whether your strengths are in line with the role you're applying for.
   How to respond: Be honest and authentic Use your personality test results to guide you if you're unsure Make sure the strengths you share align with the role

5. **What are your weaknesses?** Sometimes your strengths can also be your weaknesses. Think of it this way, let's say one of your strengths is the fact that you're honest. This can be a weakness in that being too honest can hurt sensitive individuals.
   How to respond: Be self-aware, accountable and honest Share how you are working on improving your weaknesses

6. **Why should we hire you?** Interviewers can determine whether you are passionate about the position or are simply looking for a way out of your current situation. Provide them with factual answers.
   How to respond: Provide them with compelling, yet honest reasons Provide them with testimonials by others so you don't seem self-absorbed

7. **Why do you want to leave your current position?** This is to determine whether you are looking for a way out as employers are rather looking for someone who is running towards an opportunity instead of running away from circumstances.
   How to respond: Praise your previous roles and employers. Nobody wants to work with a complainer. Show gratitude when things did not turn out the way you wanted

8. **Describe your most difficult situation** An employer normally asks this question to determine what your definition of difficult is and also how you handled this difficult situation.
   How to respond: Have a relevant story to share. Explain how you impacted the situation for the better Describe the steps you took to improve the situation

9. **Tell me about a time you failed or made a mistake** Admitting to mistakes shows you are mature, responsible and accountable. It is important to note that you have learnt from past experiences. Mistakes are inevitable but the answer lies in how you have handled them.
   How to respond: Use a relevant and honest example Provide the reason on why it was a mistake Explain how you fixed the mistakes

10. **Describe a time where you had to learn something quickly** This question assists in determining whether you are a fast learner and are comfortable with change. Interviewers are looking to identify your strategy to gather and process information quickly and effectively.
    How to respond: Choose a rich example and explain why it was challenging Break down your learning process into steps to explain Share a clear result with pride and dignity

11. **What are your salary expectations?** If this is one of the first questions an employer or interviewer asks, chances are that they are working on a tight budget. If this question arises later in the interview, they may expect that your salary requirements are in line with that they budgeted.
    How to respond: Do research and determine what the general salary expectations are for similar roles in your area Don't give them exact numbers, rather talk about ranges Motivate that you are an exceptional worker and emphasise your strengths

12. **Do you have any questions for me?** As with "tell me about yourself", this unstructured question is not used to make sure that all your questions were answered but rather to see if you are at all curious and interested in the company and position.
    How to respond: Have a couple of questions prepared beforehand Ask engaging questions that show you are interested Avoid no-brainer questions or ones related to income and benefits.

## Did you know?

Did you know, according to a study by Business2Community, 76% of resumes that come from an embarrassing email address like niknacksforlife@gmail.com or ilikegirls@icloud.com are simply thrown out. The reason for this is that seems unprofessional and distasteful. Stick to using your name and surname and if that is not available add some digits.

# Social media presence

These days, it is vital that your presence is on social media. Social media personal and business profiles are being used by most. Having a social media account is central to the existence of any business or individual trying to advertise their products or services. Just like you probably researching your new potential employer using social media, so too do other people. Therefore your social media presence says a lot about you.

Considering that people and organisations use social media to determine whether you are a good fit for a role, it would make sense to use social media to communicate your intended message.

## Instagram

If you have an Instagram account, consider the following to draw the right attention:

- Create an amazing Instagram bio
- Socialise with your followers
- Do creative activities that involve your followers
- Work with like-minded creatives
- Add a call to action option to ensure you are easily accessible
- Make use of Hashtags to ensure visibility
- Use stories to keep followers engaged
- Keep a strong eye on viewer engagement

## Facebook

For Facebook you can look at the following::

- Most people search for businesses on Facebook
- Reach new clients by making everything sharable
- Generate sales by offering special prices
- Join groups to engage with other creatives
- Stay connected to clients in Messenger. Be vigilant in responding to questions.

## LinkedIn

LinkedIn is like Facebook for Business
Consider the following aspects to up your game:

- Keep your profile information clear
- Use a business profile image of yourself rather than an informal image
- Headlines will help you sell yourself
- Spend time working on a great summary to attract potential employers
- Keep a list of skills up to date.
- Recommendation helps build your foundation
- You don't have to accept every Connection request

# Freelance platforms

Getting your foot in the door is not easy but nothing in life worth having is easy. You will not become a successful designer overnight, but I can share with you some great resources that will assist you in streamlining the process. Freelance marketplace websites or platforms are used by creatives around the world. If you think about it, you can serve anyone with your skill irrespective of where they're from.

Starting with Fivesquid (www.fivesquid.com). Originally started in Britain, this online platform allows you to trade your skills and services. The name comes from the fact that services start from £5. You don't need to charge £5, however, as you gain more confidence, skill, and have some great reviews from happy clients, you can charge a higher rate.

Fiverr (www.fiverr.com) works similar to Fivesquid where you offer your services based on a rate that fits your skill and experience. Things might start slow using these platforms but if you have the time and you put in the effort, you will soon get a great deal of work. Companies that have hired using Fiver include Facebook, Netflix, PayPal and Google

A variety of major companies, including Facebook Amazon, Nasa and IBM make use of freelancers on Freelancer (www.freelancer.com). As with the other platforms, freelancers are rated and based on your rating, your work will be influenced. So, it remains up to you to deliver on time, and provide professional service to your clients

Just to give you more options, Upwork (www.upwork.com) is another great freelance online platform to showcase your work and provide services to customers on a global scale. The great thing about these platforms is that it caters for almost any type of service or product that can be delivered on a global scale. From Writing, engineering, customer service, administrational support as well as web and design.

# Demo: Social media avatar

An avatar is a figure or icon representing a person. It is normally used as profile pictures for video games and on a variety of internet forums including social media. In this demo, Phyf will share with you his speciality of creating a digital illustration. You will learn how to create a pixel art avatar that you can add to your Facebook, Instagram or other internet platforms.

*Please refer to video lesson for demo*

# Conclusion

Whether you are applying for work as a designer at an agency or other company or if you prefer to go the freelance route, being prepared and knowing these industry tips will surely nudge you in the right direction.

The skills that you've learnt today are mostly related to corporate relations. If you are considering becoming a freelance creative or whether you prefer to work at a company, you will most certainly be faced with the topics we addressed today. From working with different personalities, albeit a client or colleague to needing to answer difficult questions during an interview and how to prepare for these.

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